in rural India. Cart ruts from Harappa show that even the axle-gauge was almost exactly the same as that of carts used in today's Sindh. The streets of Mohenjodaro, Harappa and Dholavira would have been full of these bullock-carts ferrying goods and merchants. Thousands of years later, French traveller Tavernier would speak of how seventeenth-century Indian highways were clogged by bullock-cart caravans that could have as many as 10,000–12,000 oxen. He goes on to describe how, when two such caravans met on a narrow road, there would be a traffic jam and it could take two or three days for them to pass. One can imagine Harappan highways would have been quite similar. [4] Perhaps it was one of the great continuities of Indian history.

The numerous rivers of the region would have been useful waterways for ferrying goods and people. A dry dock has been discovered at Lothal in Gujarat where vessels would have docked. It is a short drive from modern Ahmedabad and is worth a day-trip. Little more than foundations and drains have survived of the urban settlement and the visitor may need help from the friendly staff of the archaeology museum (across the car park) to make sense of it. However, the dock—the world's earliest known—is an impressive structure. It was connected by a canal to the estuary of the Sabarmati river and a lock-gate system was used to regulate water flow during tides. Next to the dock are the remains of warehouses. Standing on the brick blocks of the warehouses, I imagined the humourless customs officials who would have peered suspiciously at the merchandise being unloaded from the boats.

There is strong evidence that the Harappans traded actively with the Persian Gulf. The merchant ships likely hugged the Makran coast, perhaps with a pit stop at Sutkagen-dor and then sailed on to the ports of the Persian Gulf. Mesopotamian tablets mention a land called Meluhha that exported bead jewellery, copper, wood, peacocks, monkeys and ivory [5] . These sound like goods that Indians would have exported. It is also likely that they exported cotton textiles since the Harappans were the world pioneers in the